

Existentialism



In the 19th century, some philosophers rejected the objective stance of most philosophy to focus instead on subjective human experience. Søren Kierkegaard was probably the first to identify the feeling of confusion and anxiety when faced with the freedom to make decisions in an apparently meaningless world, and he and later Nietzsche examined the way our choices define the nature of our existence. Although neither called themselves existentialists, their ideas formed the basis for the philosophical approach later known as existentialism. Edmund Husserl's phenomenology, which proposed that we put aside all unanswerable questions and base our philosophy on the world we know was highly influential, particularly on

Martin Heidegger, who explained more rigorously the feelings of disorientation first described by Kierkegaard. Phenomenology was further developed by Maurice Merleau-Ponty, and after the Second World War, this subjective philosophical approach was popularized as existentialism in the literary philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre and Albert Camus.